

MHC in DC Independent Study Guide

Fall 2026

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Welcome!

This is an online guide for Mount Holyoke students undertaking an independent study (POLIT 395) while spending the fall semester living, learning, and interning in Washington, DC.

As an integral part of the DC program, the independent study offers you the opportunity to take a deep dive into a political science-related topic of your choice. This guide offers step-by-step advice to assist you as you develop your project from an initial idea to a polished research paper.

What's in this guide

This guide begins by providing you with the **big picture** of the research process. Like researchers in other social science disciplines, like economics or sociology, political scientists ultimately want to explain aspects of the social and political world. What sets political scientists apart from journalists, pundits, or other political commentators is our commitment to transparency. When it comes to social science research, it's not just *what* you found that's important but also *how* you found it.

Additionally, while developing an enhanced understanding of the political world is valuable for its own sake, an underlying motivation for most political scientists is to understand the world *in order to make it better*. Thus, a common feature of most social science is **problem-oriented research**: our work begins with a problem or puzzle of general concern which requires explanation before society can respond to it effectively.

Fortunately, we don't need to tackle these problems on our own. Rather, social scientists undertake research within communities of likeminded scholars, who are also researching similar or sometimes even the same problem or puzzle as we are. By **joining these ongoing conversations**, we benefit from generations of past and contemporary scholars, inheriting the accumulated knowledge of the discipline, and drawing from it as we make our own modest contribution.

Specifically, despite the apparent novelties of things like Artificial Intelligence (AI) or the presidency of Donald Trump, very few things in our world are actually brand new. Though it may be true that AI is a very distinctive kind of technology and that there's never been an American president quite like Donald Trump, they are both instances of broader phenomena: disruptive innovations on the one hand, right-wing populists on the other. What's good about

looking at new developments in this way is that there is usually some existing **theory** to draw on when trying to explain them. By turning to the existing political science literature we can think abstractly about how disruptive innovations are likely to affect democracy, or about how populist presidents are likely to challenge checks and balances. Whether we are applying existing theory to new problems or creating a new theory from scratch, thinking abstractly about concepts and relationships can give us some preliminary understanding of novel developments.

To see if a theory actually helps us explain the political problems that concern us, political scientists draw out some empirical implications, or **hypotheses**, to test. We simply ask ourselves: *if my theory was true, what would I expect to see in the world?* Our strategy for **collecting the evidence or data** for testing our hypotheses is called our **research design**.

Verifying that world works as our theory suggests

How to use this guide

This guide contains

1 Introduction: The Big Picture

The research paper workflow

Let's start by taking a bird's eye view of this semester's research project as a whole. Figure 1.1 displays a diagram representing the research workflow, starting and ending with the state of existing knowledge.

There's a lot going on in this diagram, so let's explain it piece by piece. The blue-shaded bubbles represent distinct stages of the research process. The solid arrows trace a clockwise workflow from **topic** in the top-right corner to **findings and implications** near the top-left. The dashed arrows trace a counter-clockwise workflow back through the stages. This is meant to capture that although the workflow looks chronological, real-world research typically iterates back and forth between stages, recursively revising and refining previous stages as we move forward to new ones.

There are also two red-shaded deliverables that are spun out of the workflow at various points. A formal **research proposal** is expected around the midpoint in the semester and a polished **research paper** is expected at the end.

As the semester proceeds, we'll spend significant time unpacking each and every one of these stages as you move your project through the research workflow. I'll also clarify precisely what is expected in the research proposal and paper. The chapters that follow do precisely that. For now, to get a better sense of the big picture, let's take a brief tour through the workflow.

Existing knowledge

All research projects begin and end with the state of existing knowledge. We draw from it when we learn about a subject that interests us, and we contribute to it when we communicate our research findings to audiences and stakeholders. As researchers, our intention is to extend the frontiers of knowledge, even if only modestly, leaving the field in a better place than when we found it.

Topic, problem/puzzle, question

While existing knowledge typically plays an implicit, background role, in the formation of research projects, specific topics, problems, puzzles, or questions are usually top of mind in the formation of research projects.

Join the conversation

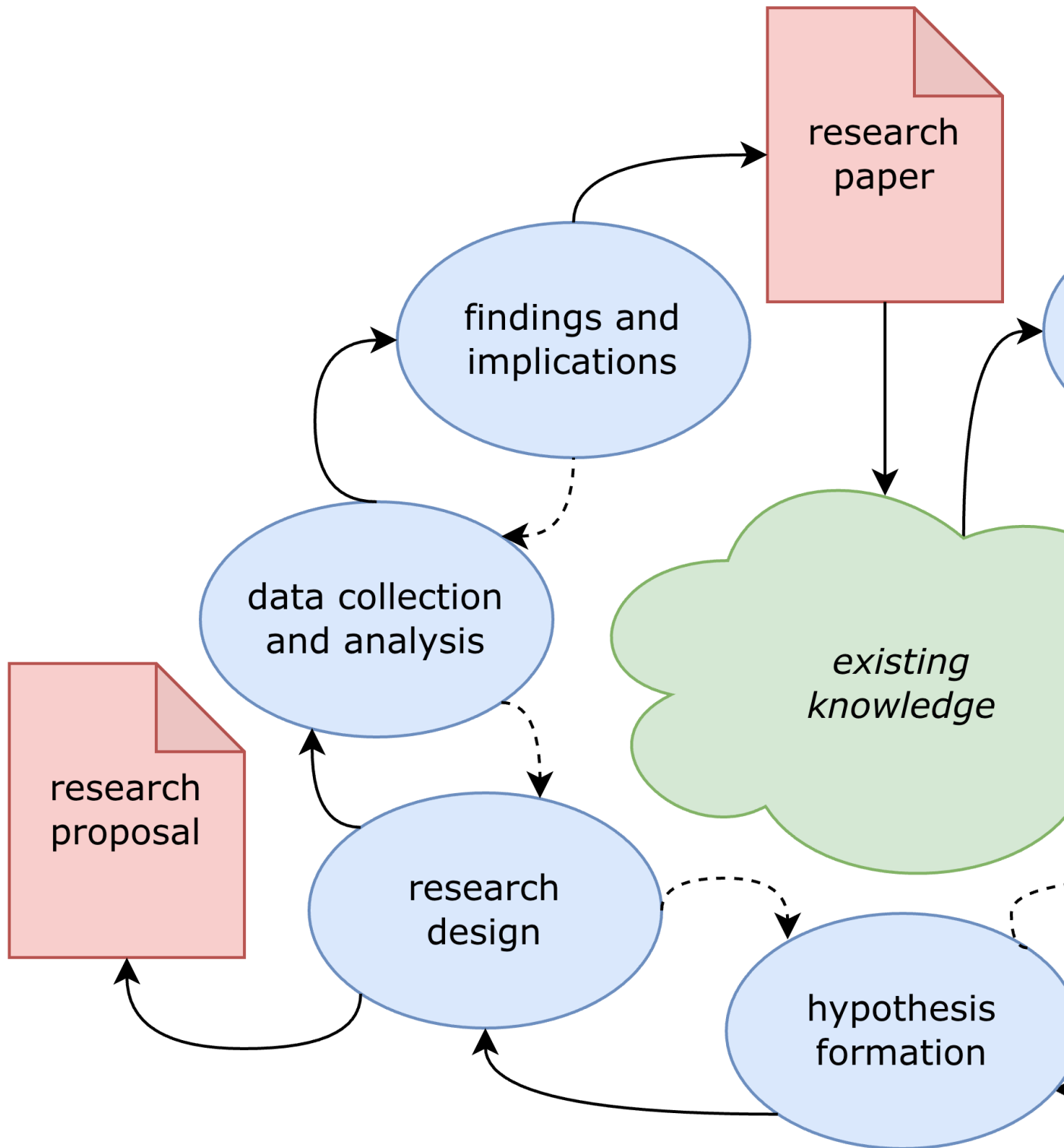


Figure 1.1: The research workflow

Theory and hypotheses

Research design

Data collection and analysis

Findings and implications

Inference is the goal

There's a common misconception among new students in the social sciences that they will find a single correct answer to their research question—something along the lines of, say, $2 + 2 = 4$.

Inference is simply the act of making claims that go beyond the particular evidence examined (King et al. 1994).

But if by *answer* we mean a transparently reasoned, evidence-based conclusion that is amenable to future updating based on new evidence, then let me reassure you that you're ready for the challenge that awaits you.

The process by which we arrive at this transparently reasoned, evidence-based, and always-tentative conclusion goes by the name **inference**, and it is the basis of all social science research. According to its [Wikipedia entry](#), inference is simply a “conclusion reached on the basis of evidence and reasoning.” Why must we infer?

We make so many inferences in our everyday lives, we may not even consciously notice. When we wake up and find that the sidewalk is wet, we infer that it rained overnight. When you see a friend sitting down to have a snack, you may infer that they're hungry. If you find your roommate packing a bag, you might infer that they are going away for the weekend.

In the social sciences, we make inferences about other kinds of phenomena, but the logic is the same. After observing a polity's electoral process, we may classify the regime as either a democracy or an autocracy. To survey public opinion, we typically rely on a representative sample from which we generalize about the whole population. If the economy enters a recession, we may expect an incumbent's chances of reelection to diminish.

These examples of inference from both everyday life and the social sciences have something in common: they all occur under conditions of **uncertainty**. This is why social science research is fundamentally unlike concluding that $2 + 2 = 4$. The simple definition of the equation's symbols provides us with complete information and makes the conclusion logically inescapable. We can claim that $2 + 2 = 4$ with absolute certainty.

When it comes to social science, we are not so lucky. Typically, we operate with incomplete information and must form our conclusions carefully to account for uncertainty. We may think that it was the economic recession that doomed the president's reelection, but perhaps it was a corruption scandal that was top of mind for voters that year. Needing to do our research under

conditions of uncertainty makes social science challenging but also interesting and ultimately rewarding.

Inference and explanation

The centrality of inference to social science research may feel a little deflating at first. It is natural to want to find clear and definite answers to questions of widespread public concern and political importance. Does the ubiquity of uncertainty mean that we can't really explain anything?

Why do much uncertainty? There are multiple sources of uncertainty when conducting research on the social and political world (Gailmard 2014, 73).

A pluralist methodology

I'll conclude this introductory chapter with a brief statement intended to clarify the methodological underpinnings of the research advice contained in this book. Social science can be thought of as a mansion with many rooms, each of which is occupied by specialized topics of interest (e.g. political science, economics, sociology, etc.), different methods of inquiry (quantitative or qualitative), and distinct communicative styles. Getting out of your own room to drop in on your neighbors to see what their up to is a healthy and encouraged practice. But trying to squeeze a full tour of the mansion into a short guide book is impractical.

Philosophically, this book embraces what's called methodological pluralism. This particular view of social science follows from the principles laid out above. If we as researchers operate under conditions of uncertainty and our inferences are always tentative and subject to revision, then it's best that we take a broadly inclusive approach to social science research. Gatekeeping—that is, judging what is and *is not* legitimate social science—can be a harmful and unproductive practice, and is

This is not the same as saying that social science is a field in which “anything goes.” As we've established, there are standards that must be met.

2 From Topic to Question

If social scientists' ultimate goal is to explain the social and political world, it's unsurprising that research projects typically spring from a problem or puzzle that initially defies explanation.

3 Joining the Conversation

4 Theory and Hypotheses

4.1 Introduction

Whether we consciously realize it or not, we humans engage with our everyday surroundings by constantly constructing, deploying, and revising mental models of how the world works. These models may be flawed, incomplete, or even downright wrong. Nevertheless, so long as they prove useful for our particular purpose, we continue to use them.

Social scientists concerned with explaining how aspects of the social and political world works build models too. Unlike most of the mental models we walk around with unconsciously, social scientists must make their models explicit by articulating **theories**, expressed in the form of either words, diagrams, mathematics, or all of the above.

Simply put, theories are just relationships between concepts, linked together by a set of assumptions made explicit by whomever is building the model. As such, theories are neither true nor false in themselves—no more so than a painting or a subway map is true or false. A model is simply a representation of reality, designed with a particular purpose in mind (Clarke and Primo 2012). A Picasso-style portrait, though visually appealing, will not work for a passport photo. Nor will a subway map be very useful if you are navigating a city on foot.

<Picasso and subway map images side by side>

The usefulness of any particularly theory is found in how well it helps us explain the empirical phenomena it predicts. Which theory is more likely given the evidence?

In short, a theory is a proposed answer to a research question. Theory development is the process of “identifying numerous potential explanations [to your question] and then sifting through them to find the one that you feel is the most likely or strongest explanation of the phenomenon” (Powner 2026, 34).

We address theory development and hypothesis formation together in this chapter because they so often go hand-in-hand during actual research.

4.2 Visualizing theory with DAGs

5 Research Design

6 Research Proposal

7 Data Collection and Analysis

7.1 Common Data Resources in Political Science

This section (borrowed from Powner (2026)) contains an extensive collection of dataset links. If you can imagine it, there's a VERY good chance someone else has already collected data on it, and one of these sites has a link to it. If you're struggling to find appropriate data, let me know.

University Libraries

https://guides.libraries.emory.edu/main/Data_Services/govinstlinks (Also their US States page)

<https://guides.lib.umich.edu/?b=s> Hundreds of field-specific guides to research data; use the Search tool for easiest access

<https://libguides.princeton.edu/politics/data> – good collection of data for beginners

Cross-Subfield

www.poliscidata.com Barry Edwards has an INCREDIBLE collection of data sets from across the field, organized by subfield and topic. If you know what you want, this is the place to go.

<https://dataverse.harvard.edu/> Data archive. Contains both article data (often organized by publication name) and archives for larger or longer-running data collection programs.

<https://datasetsearch.research.google.com/> Google has a dataset search tool. It's NOT my favorite, but if you are looking for a unique piece of data or something from outside conventional political science themes, this may be helpful. (Recommended for more advanced users.)

Dataset with Political Datasets <https://github.com/erikgahner/PolData> Databases catalogued by content and links. Collection of cross-national election studies, cabinet data, political institutions, constitutions, parties & politicians, governance, economics, and more

American Politics

<https://electionstudies.org/> – The American National Election Studies datasets are the gold standard for US political behavior, with 75 years of data and nearly 10,000 citations. Most people start with the question search tool. Much data available for political psychology, race & politics, and attitudes towards public figures, groups and issues.

Cooperative Election Study (Formerly Cooperative Congressional Election Study)

<https://tischcollege.tufts.edu/research-faculty/research-centers/cooperative-election-study>
Starting in 2006, the study captures large numbers of Americans (think 50,000 respondents a year) before and after each national election. Besides a common content module asked of all respondents, teams of researchers add additional thematic modules that typically get asked of 1,000-2,000 respondents. Many unique theme modules thus exist in this data, though it's a bit more difficult to navigate.

State Politics & Policy Quarterly data resource https://web.archive.org/web/20150311202414/https://academic.udayton.edu/SPPQ-TPR/tpr_data_sets.html

Correlates of State Policy <https://ippsr.msu.edu/public-policy/correlates-state-policy> State policy adoptions and changes over time, plus associated state-level variables

State Ideology Data: <https://rcfording.wordpress.com/state-ideology-data/>

Non-US and Comparative Politics

Varieties of Democracy (V-Dem) <https://www.v-dem.net/> WAY more than just democracy – all sorts of political and economic institution data in one place. Often the first stop for building cross-national datasets.

Polity <https://www.systemicpeace.org/> The baseline institutional measure of democracy for decades. Data stop around 2020 for technical reasons.

Comparative Agendas Project <https://www.comparativeagendas.net/> What are the hot political issues in various countries and US states over time? Only a few US states have their own data, but lots of cool country-based data.

Database of Political Institutions (Interamerican Development Bank) <https://data.iadb.org/dataset/the-database-of-political-institutions-dpi-2020> Publicly accessible, 45 years, 180 countries

<https://github.com/erikgahner/PolData> Collection of cross-national election studies, cabinet data, political institutions, constitutions, parties & politicians, governance, economics, and more

Comparative Study of Electoral Systems <https://cses.org/> National electoral studies designed to be comparable. Includes most moderately or fully democratic countries.

National Elections Across Democracy and Autocracy (NELDA) <http://nelda.co/> Data organized by election round for all recognized countries in the world. Data access by (very simple) request.

International Relations

THOUSANDS of specialized IR datasets exist. <https://github.com/erikgahner/PolData> and Poliscidata.com catalog many titles thematically.

Design of International Trade Agreements (DESTA) <https://www.designoftradeagreements.org/downloads/> Treaties list, withdrawals, agreement content

Alliance Treaty Obligations Project (ATOP) <http://www.atopdata.org/> All military alliances formed between 1815-2018 along with their provisions; [NEWGENE replacement] allows easy combination with conflict data

Cignarelli-Richardson Human Rights Data (CIRI) – <https://dataverse.harvard.edu/dataverse/cirihumanrightsdata> The most respected non-governmental measurement of human rights

Correlates of War project (COW) <https://correlatesofwar.org/> best known for war data, militarized interstate disputes (MIDs), and national material capabilities, but many other security related topics are available (contiguity, defense cooperation, shared international organization membership, etc.)

Global Terrorism Database <https://www.start.umd.edu/data-tools/GTD> domestic & transnational terrorism

International Crisis Behavior Events – <https://www.crisisevents.org/> crises smaller than wars or militarized interstate disputes Social Conflict Analysis Database (SCAD) – Africa & Latin America/Caribbean; riots, strikes, protests, government violence against civilians.

8 Findings and Implications

9 Research Paper

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